



DULCE RAMIREZ works at a store in the Fashion District and said it's been difficult getting new employees.

MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times

Uber pushes to cap lawyer payouts

Measure would limit fees in crash cases, setting up ballot fight with trial attorneys.

By REBECCA ELLIS

The long-simmering fight between some of L.A.'s best-known billboard attorneys and Uber, one of their most frequent targets, is poised to spill out of the courtroom and onto the November ballot.

The ride-hailing giant is gathering signatures for an initiative that, if passed by voters, would cap how much attorneys can earn in vehicle collision cases. The company pledges the change will give victims a larger cut of their settlement money, alleging predatory attorneys are inflating medical bills to increase their profits.

Lawyers claim it will decimate their lucrative niche — car crash lawsuits in the automobile haven that is California — and ultimately leave thousands of people with small or challenging cases unable to sue because they can't find an attorney.

This fight, lawyers say, is existential.

Attorneys from Sweet James and Jacoby & Meyers — the names and faces of which will be imprinted in the minds of most California drivers — have given almost \$1 million to a committee opposing the ballot measure, according to campaign filings. Dozens of other deep-pocketed attorneys have joined, raising an impressive war chest already surpassing \$46 million.

"Uber knows darn well what they've done," said Nicholas Rowley, among those leading the opposition. "This law is designed to wipe out ordinary working people's ability to get representation."

Attorneys have condemned the fee cap as a Trojan horse meant to trick voters into wrecking the delicate math behind personal injury lawsuits. Currently, personal injury attorneys typically take 33% to 40% of a client's payout. That is enough, they say, for them to earn a living and risk taking cases on a contingency fee basis — meaning, if they lose, they don't get paid.

Uber's proposal would cap attorney fees for car crash cases at 25% and require extra costs — filing fees, depositions, experts — to be calculated before the fee split rather than coming out of the client's portion.

The two sides have conflicting views of who would be expected to pay for medi-

[See Uber, A8]

Venezuela's revolution stands at a crossroads

U.S. strike leaves Chavismo's future in doubt

By Kate Linthicum, Ian James and Patrick J. McDonnell

MEXICO CITY — Hugo Chávez called the United States "the empire," and President George W. Bush "the devil." Denouncing capitalism as "the road to hell," he pushed an alternative economic model that nationalized key industries and redistributed wealth.

During his 14-year presidency of Venezuela, Chávez warned of a CIA plot to kill him and steal his country's vast oil reserves, declaring: "Fatherland, socialism or death!"

Now, after the U.S. attacked Venezuela and imprisoned Chávez's successor,

Nicolás Maduro, the future of the leftist movement forged by Chávez — known as Chavismo — may be at stake.

Venezuela's interim leader, Delcy Rodríguez, insists her country "will not be a colony" of any imperial force, but appears willing to tolerate President Trump's demands that the U.S. get "total access" to Venezuela's oil.

Rodríguez, Maduro's vice president, has called for reforms to Venezuela's energy sector to attract foreign investment and has freed dozens of dissidents once

[See Chavismo, A3]



JESUS VARGAS Getty Images

A WOMAN holds a bust of late President Hugo Chávez at a rally in 2024.

'America first' comes to parks

Staff at Yosemite and Sequoia are required to ask visitors about U.S. residency status.

By KAREN GARCIA

If you're planning to visit one of the 11 most popular national parks in the U.S. — two of which are in California — staff might ask a question that could be disquieting: Are you a resident of the United States?

A spokesperson for the Department of the Interior said that the question is being posed only to confirm whether the visitor will have to pay a nonresident fee — which is hefty.

The update to visitor verification and fees was announced in November by the Trump administration, which said that beginning Jan. 1 it would implement "America-first" entry fee policies.

"U.S. residents will continue to enjoy affordable pricing, while nonresidents

will pay a higher rate to help support the care and maintenance of America's parks," according to the announcement.

The move is the latest in a series of incendiary tactics the Trump administration has employed in its crack-down on immigrants and foreign travelers, which has included sweeps in cities including Los Angeles and Minneapolis and suspending visas from dozens of countries, including new suspensions announced on

[See Parks, A9]



GHAITH ALSAYED Associated Press

Syria announces ceasefire

The deal with the Syrian Democratic Forces gives the government almost full control. **WORLD, A2**

Judge bars some LAPD weapons

Ruling blocks use of certain less-lethal projectiles to disperse crowds. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Artist undone, then remade

Electronic powerhouse Kaskade softens the beat in a time of tumult. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather

Lots of sunshine. L.A. Basin: 77/52. **B6**



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Immigration raid jolts L.A. Fashion District

Sweep compounds worries for shoppers and struggling business owners.

By SUHAUNA HUSSAIN AND RUBEN VIVES

In the Fashion District, workers hoisted up the metal grates protecting storefronts, strung up canopies and set up racks of clothing and signs advertising sales for \$1 accessories, \$2 shirts.

Browsing lacy stockings and harnesses Friday morning at Wendy's Lingerie on Maple Avenue, Faith Avila, 24, and her friend had no idea that a mere 24 hours before, the intersection a few yards away had been locked down by federal agents. Or that the store she was browsing in had shut down the rest of the day as a result.

Federal agents had carried out an immigration sweep, unsettling shoppers and distressing business owners who were struggling from last year's enforcement operations.

The sweep took place late Thursday morning near Maple Avenue and 11th

Street. Videos shared on social media show armed agents standing in the middle of the intersection while a procession of unmarked vehicles turned onto 11th.

Witnesses reported seeing the agents visiting vendors and requesting proof of citizenship. It was not immediately clear whether anyone had been taken into custody.

In an email response to The Times, a Department of Homeland Security spokesperson did not provide details of the operation but said that federal immigration agents would continue to operate in the city.

Thursday's sweep came less than a year after the Trump administration kicked off its mass deportation campaign at the Fashion District, a popular shopping area covering more than 100 blocks of L.A.'s downtown and home to more than 4,000 independently and minority-owned businesses, many of them with predominantly Latino workers.

In June, federal immigration agents targeted four businesses in the shopping district.

[See Raid, A9]

MINNEAPOLIS: Somali businesses are quiet as owners and customers are afraid to go out. **NATION, A6**

8 European allies call Trump threat a 'dangerous' risk

By STEFANIE DAZIO, JILL LAWLESS AND EMMA BURROWS

BERLIN — The eight European countries targeted by President Trump for a 10% tariff for opposing American control of Greenland denounced the move Sunday, warning that his threats "undermine transatlantic relations and risk a dangerous downward spiral."

The joint statement by some of America's closest allies signaled a possible turning point in the recent tensions over sovereignty and security nearly 24 hours after Trump's threat.

It was also the most forceful rebuke of Trump from the European allies

since he returned to the White House almost a year ago. In recent months, Europeans have mostly opted for diplomacy and flattery around him, even when seeking an end to the war in Ukraine. Sunday's statement, coming after some European countries recently sent troops to Greenland for a Danish military training exercise, appeared to be a step back from that strategy.

The unusually strong joint statement from Denmark, Norway, Sweden, France, Germany, the United Kingdom, the Netherlands and Finland said troops sent to Greenland for an operation dubbed Arctic Endurance pose "no threat to anyone."

Danish Foreign Minister [See Tariffs, A4]

Crumbling legacy: Dead local malls plagued by blight

By HANNAH FRY

For generations, the Westminster Mall operated akin to a town square for central Orange County — a place to socialize and be seen.

It's where teenagers strolled hand in hand on first dates, where parents took their kids to catch the latest box office hit and even the most frustrating day of shopping could be improved with a giant pretzel or cinnamon roll from the food court.

When it closed last year, there were tears and even a funeral for the Orange County relic. But that was just the beginning of the indignity for the beloved mall.

In recent days, videos have circulated on social media showing rampant vandalism and destruction inside the massive structure. The images, which have angered and saddened locals who spent their youth there,

have become a symbol of how many malls end their lives — not with celebration but with years of decay and, ultimately, defacement.

"There's still a legacy and respect that these spaces deserve," said Alexis Malatesta, who frequented the Westminster Mall during her youth in Huntington Beach. "Just because it's going to be torn down doesn't mean you should go in there and just deface it and annihilate it."

The Westminster Mall, which first opened in 1974, was most recently home to big department stores like JCPenney and mall staples such as Victoria's Secret and Auntie Anne's. The mall, like many others across California, is expected to eventually be transformed into a mixed-use development with retail space and housing.

As malls have closed due to shifting consumer shopping habits and a desire for [See Malls, A7]